hunt that the elderly head of state received training on the weapon but was a miserable shot.)

‘When hunting, Honecker was a different person. Here he could laugh – even if he was due to sign a death warrant,’ Dieter Wlost, one of his former woodland rangers, once said.1

For deep forest expeditions, Honecker commissioned several souped-up four-wheel-drive vehicles, including a Land Rover converted by the West-Berlin company, Karosserie Friedrich Rometsch. Modifications – plush interior, collapsible roof, gun racks and extension for carrying animal carcasses – cost the East German taxpayer DM150,000, or four times the original value of the car. The First Secretary approved every detail and personally designed a variable gun-support for the rear door.

Like a country squire, he polished his hound skills and on one occasion – in a saga that had some elements of a French farce – he instructed his underlings to scour the country to find a suitable hunting dog. Funnily enough, the search was picked up by agents from the FRG: ‘A 3½-year-old short-haired pointer had been found in Erfurt, but the owner wanted DDM3,800 but only received DDM2,500, along with a 7x65, caliber 12, block gun and the return of his confiscated gun licence.’2

Every year, Honecker bagged around 100 deer, plus hundreds of hares. On one September evening in the 1980s, according to hunting logs, he shot five deer in a row. In order to satisfy his passion, neither expense nor effort was spared in fencing the entire Schorfheide to contain the game, while dozens of forest wardens maintained the animal population. ‘Honecker’s addiction to hunting even led him to demand that the game population be improved through imports,’ recalls forester Horst Mildner. ‘And so, animals were introduced, such as red deer from Hungary.’ Bodyguard Bernd Brückner remembered ‘trophies’ were measured, photographed and certified in the presence of the General Secretary. ‘That was a ritual,’ he recounted, ‘you could feel a real joy, even exuberance from Honecker.’ What was particularly remarkable was that Honecker ‘ate nothing, absolutely nothing from the forest. He did not eat mushrooms and he certainly did not eat game.’